

A CLASH OF KNIGHTS

THE BATTLE OF BOUVINES

Though medieval rulers often launched military campaigns, they were wary of pitched battles. The meeting of European armies at Bouvines in 1214 was a rare clash between large bodies of knights, a set-piece battle that epitomized the fighting style of the era's armoured horsemen.

In the summer of 1214, King Philip II of France faced an army led by the Holy Roman Emperor Otto IV and Ferdinand, Count of Flanders. The two armies encountered one another near Bouvines in Flanders on 27 July, and engaged in battle. The French king was accompanied by his feudal lords and their armed followers, and by citizen militia from the towns. The Imperial army – Germans, Flemings, and English – was similarly structured, ranging from noblemen to the armed artisans of the Flemish towns. Both sides also employed mercenaries, fighting for pay or plunder.

It was symmetrical warfare, the two sides fighting with the same weapons (mainly edged or percussion *mêlée* weapons), tactics, and military codes. Both armies were drawn up with armoured horsemen – nobles, knights, and unknighthed sergeants – on the flanks, and foot soldiers in the centre. The king and the emperor each placed himself behind the infantry in the midst of his household knights, who formed a cavalry reserve. The field was dotted with banners – a practical visual identification for the different feudal contingents. The Imperial army was larger, with around 25,000 men against 15,000 French, but the numbers of mounted men on each side were similar, probably about 4,000. Philip's army spread out thinly, matching the length of the enemy line to avoid being outflanked.

CLOSE COMBAT

The battle began without clear plan or central command. Amid a cacophony of trumpets, shouted insults, and prayers, some of the armies' troops attacked, while others hesitated or

stood on the defensive. Bodies of knights lowered their lances and charged the facing cavalry, their lances shattering on impact, while some nobles sought out particular enemies against whom they held a grudge. Although knights would not shy away from clashes with infantry, they preferred to engage their peers; it was sometimes seen as degrading to fight against opponents of lower social status. However, soon such distinctions were lost as a vast *mêlée* broke out across the battlefield. Knights hacked at one another with swords, daggers, axes, and maces. Their mail armour and plate helmets were resistant to most blows, but horses were more vulnerable: many savagely wounded mounts fell, bringing their riders to the ground. Foot soldiers also proved adept at unhorsing knights, snagging their armour with hooks and spears. Philip himself was unhorsed by Flemish infantry, and was lucky to escape with his life.

Eventually the French gained the upper hand, their horsemen emerging victorious. In the centre, the emperor was overrun and his banner captured, although Otto himself escaped the field. The last of the Imperial forces to hold out was Renaud of Boulogne, a doughty fighter who organized 700 pikemen in a circle, keeping the French knights at bay using the reach of their weapons. When they fell, the battle ended. Three counts, 25 barons, and about 100 knights were led off as privileged prisoners: it was not considered dishonourable to surrender and, because of the financial value of ransom, surrender was usually accepted. Thus, few nobles or knights fought to the death.

